A more comprehensive assessment of China's role is essential to understanding the past trajectory of US-India relations. It can also shed light on the China-India-US triangle of today and of tomorrow. Moreover, it can help answer the often-asked question these days about the fate of this triangle: whether India and the US can and will ally or partner against China, given converging concerns about its rise, intentions, and actions.

This book shows that China's centrality to US-India relations is not a recent phenomenon; it dates back to the beginning of the two democracies' relations. Indeed, the story of that relationship and its ups and downs cannot be adequately told without systematically considering the China effect.

This book explores and disentangles how American and Indian perceptions of and policy toward China shaped US-India relations during a formative period: 1949–1979. Why these three decades? The onset of this period was when the Chinese Communist Party–led People's Republic of China came into existence. It was also a crucial time in the development of US perceptions of newly independent India and vice versa. Over the next three decades and multiple American and Indian administrations, in direct and indirect ways, Delhi and Washington's perceptions of Beijing affected how they saw and behaved toward each other. In 1978–1979 the ascension of Deng Xiaoping and the onset of reform constituted a turning point for China. It marked the formal US recognition of China, and a key milestone in the normalization of India's relations with China after the 1962 Sino-Indian war. Developments then set the stage for the US-China-India triangle of today, a topic deserving of its own book.

It was China, and not Pakistan's military alliance with the US, as is commonly understood, that brought the Cold War to India's doorstep. And between 1949 and 1956, China was a key driver of US-India divergence. It did not have to be that way—after communists took over China, the Truman administration indeed hoped that India would play a critical role in the US strategic script as a geopolitical counterbalance and ideological democratic contrast to the Soviet Union's Asian ally. However, the Indian government, led by Jawaharlal Nehru, had a different perspective and would not play the role that the US envisioned for it. Delhi worried about development competition with communist China, but believed that any geopolitical threat was years away. And it thought that engaging China and